RIVYLS

Draft Programs. Not Players.

MARKETING PLAN & LAUNCH TIMELINE

Solo Founder Playbook for the 2026 College Football Season

February 2026

CONFIDENTIAL

Table of Contents

1. The Critical Calendar: Why Timing Is Everything3
2. Realistic Launch Timeline (February - September 2026)4
3. Marketing Strategy: The 4 Channels That Matter7
4. Commissioner Acquisition Deep Dive9
5. Weekly Time Allocation by Phase11
6. What NOT to Do (Channels to Avoid)12
7. Realistic Outcome Scenarios13
8. Year 1 Pricing Strategy14
9. Key Metrics & Tracking15
10. Action Items: Your Next 30 Days16

1. The Critical Calendar: Why Timing Is Everything

Everything in this plan is dictated by one immovable date: the 2026 college football season kicks off around August 29-31 (Week 0/1). Every decision, deadline, and milestone works backward from that date.

The key insight: Users don't discover a platform and draft the same day. There is a 2-4 week lead time between "I heard about this" and "my league is full and we're drafting." Most commissioners will want to draft in the 1-3 weeks before the season starts (mid-August). That means your real marketing window is June through mid-August. Which means the platform needs to be functional enough for people to sign up, create a league, and invite friends by early-to-mid July.

THE NON-NEGOTIABLE DEADLINES

May 2026: Landing page live, collecting emails
Early July 2026: Platform functional (signup, league creation, invites, draft)
Mid-July 2026: Open to public, commissioner recruitment sprint begins
Mid-August 2026: Peak draft period (most leagues drafting)
Late August 2026: Season kicks off, live scoring must be operational

What "functional" means: Not polished. Not perfect. Functional. Users can register, create a league, invite friends via a shareable link, conduct a snake draft, and see the league dashboard. You can iterate on UI, polish, and secondary features throughout August and September while the platform is live. Your existing 20 MVP users have played through an entire season on Google Sheets — they have a high tolerance for rough edges.

2. Realistic Launch Timeline (February - September 2026)

Phase 1: Build Core Platform (February - April 2026)

This is heads-down development time. You already have the business logic validated through a full season of Google Sheets — the scoring rules, draft mechanics, transaction processing, school eligibility. You are not designing these systems from scratch; you are translating proven logic into a web stack.

Minimum Viable Feature Set for Launch:

Feature	Description	Priority	Est. Time
User registration / login	Supabase Auth (email + Google/Apple)	**Must-have**	2-3 days
League creation	Commissioner creates league, sets rules	**Must-have**	1 week
League invitation system	Shareable link or email invite	**Must-have**	3-4 days
Snake draft	Real-time draft with timer, pick tracking	**Must-have**	2-3 weeks
Weekly scoring (ESPN API)	Automated scoring from live game data	**Must-have**	2 weeks
Add/drop transactions	Mid-season roster moves with validation	**Must-have**	1-2 weeks
Leaderboard / standings	League rankings, total points	**Must-have**	3-4 days
User dashboard	My leagues, my roster, upcoming games	**Must-have**	1 week
Mobile-responsive UI	Works well on phone browsers	**Must-have**	Ongoing
Payment processing	Entry fees, payouts via Stripe	**NOT Year 1**	Skip
Premium analytics	Advanced stats, projections	**NOT Year 1**	Skip
Native mobile app	iOS/Android app store	**NOT Year 1**	Skip
Chat / messaging	In-app league communication	**Nice-to-have**	Skip for now
Commissioner admin tools	Advanced league management	**Nice-to-have**	Basic only

KEY DECISION: Free Leagues Only in Year 1

Do not build payment processing for Year 1. Make every league free. This saves 4-6 weeks of development time, eliminates payment-related customer service issues, removes signup friction, and avoids state-by-state money transmitter compliance questions. Your goal this year is 1,000 users playing through a full season, not revenue. Charge in Year 2 when you have retention data proving people come back.

Phase 2: Landing Page + Early Access Waitlist (May - June 2026)

This is where marketing starts before the platform is ready. You launch a simple landing page with the Rivyls brand, a clear explanation of the concept, and an email signup for early access.

Landing Page Requirements:

Headline: "Draft Programs. Not Players." — immediately communicates the differentiator.

Subhead: "The first fantasy sports platform where you become the coach. Draft entire college programs. Compete all season."

Email Capture: "Join the early access list" with a simple email field. Use a tool like Mailchimp (free up to 500 contacts) or ConvertKit.

Social Proof: "Validated by 20+ users through a full 2025 college football season" — your MVP is real proof.

Tools: Carrd.co ($19/year) for a quick one-page site, or build a simple Next.js page on Vercel (free). Either works.

The purpose of this page is threefold: it starts collecting interested users, it gives you something to link when you start community outreach, and it creates urgency through an early-access narrative.

Phase 3: Beta Launch + Commissioner Recruitment Sprint (July 2026)

Open the platform to your email waitlist first. Let your original 20 MVP users in as the first wave — they already know the game and can stress-test the web version. Their feedback in the first two weeks is worth more than anything else. Then open it publicly and run hard on commissioner recruitment for the next 4-6 weeks.

Beta Launch Checklist:

Week 1-2 of July: Invite original 20 users. Collect feedback aggressively. Fix critical bugs. This is your private beta.

Week 3 of July: Open to full email waitlist. Monitor signups, league creation rates, and any friction points in the funnel.

Week 4 of July: Public launch. Begin Reddit posts, creator outreach, and commissioner recruitment in earnest.

Phase 4: Draft Season + Live Operations (August 2026)

Most leagues will draft in August. This is your busiest operational period — monitoring the platform under load, fixing bugs in real time, and supporting commissioners through their first draft experience.

Your marketing effort shifts from acquisition to activation: making sure the people who signed up actually complete their drafts and are ready for Week 1. Send reminder emails to commissioners who created leagues but haven't drafted yet. Surface draft scheduling tools prominently. Make the draft experience as smooth as possible — this is the make-or-break moment for user retention.

Phase 5: In-Season Operations (September 2026 - January 2027)

Once the season is live, your focus shifts to retention and engagement. Weekly engagement loops are critical: scoring update emails/notifications after Saturday games, transaction window reminders, leaderboard change alerts, and matchup previews. The goal is to make Rivyls a habit tied to the college football Saturday rhythm.

This is also when you collect the data that matters for Year 2: weekly active user rates, transaction usage frequency, session length, churn timing (which week do people stop logging in?), and net promoter score from end-of-season surveys.

Master Timeline at a Glance

When	Phase	Key Activities	
Feb 2026	**Development**	Core platform build: auth, database schema, league creation, draft engine	
Mar 2026	**Development**	Draft system, ESPN API integration, scoring engine, transaction processing	
Apr 2026	**Development**	User dashboard, leaderboard, mobile responsiveness, internal testing	
May 2026	**Pre-Launch**	Landing page live, email collection begins, Reddit community engagement starts	
Jun 2026	**Pre-Launch**	Content creator outreach begins, university org outreach, continue development polish	
Early Jul	**Beta**	Private beta with 20 MVP users, bug fixing sprint, collect feedback	
Mid Jul	**Beta**	Open to email waitlist, monitor funnel, iterate on UX friction	
Late Jul	**Public Launch**	Public launch, commissioner recruitment sprint, Reddit posts, creator partnerships go live	
Aug 2026	**Draft Season**	Peak commissioner recruitment, most leagues drafting, platform monitoring, user support	
Late Aug	**Season Start**	Live scoring operational, first week of games, real-time monitoring	
Sep-Jan	**In-Season**	Weekly engagement loops, retention focus, data collection, bug fixes, feature iteration	

3. Marketing Strategy: The 4 Channels That Matter

The core principle: As a solo founder, you cannot do everything. Pick 3-4 marketing channels and execute them well. Doing 10 channels poorly is worse than doing 3 channels consistently. The following channels are ranked by expected return on your time and money.

Channel 1: Commissioner-Led Viral Growth (Highest Priority)

This is your engine. Every commissioner you recruit brings 8-12 users for free. The math is simple: if you recruit 100 commissioners, you get 800-1,200 users without spending a dollar on those individual users. This is the single most important marketing mechanism for Rivyls.

Why it works: Fantasy sports are inherently social and group-based. Nobody plays fantasy sports alone. The commissioner is the organizer, the evangelist, the person who texts the group chat saying "we're doing this." Win the commissioner, win their entire league.

How to recruit commissioners:

1. Start with your existing 20 users. Ask each of them: "Would you run a league with a different friend group?" and "Do you know anyone else who'd want to run one?" If each of your 20 users recruits 2 commissioners from their extended network, that's 40 leagues right there.

2. Build a simple referral incentive. Every commissioner who fills a league gets a "Founding Commissioner" badge (permanent status), priority access to new features, and when you do introduce paid leagues in Year 2, a free premium upgrade for life. Make it feel exclusive.

3. Make league creation and invitation effortless. One click to create a league. A shareable link to invite friends. No friction. If it takes more than 60 seconds for a commissioner to set up a league and send invites, you will lose people.

Cost: $0 in direct spend. Your time is the only investment. This is why it's the highest priority channel.

Channel 2: Reddit & Online Communities (Best Free Channel)

Reddit's r/CFB has over 2.3 million members. r/fantasyfootball has 1.2 million. These are concentrated pools of exactly your target user. But Reddit hates overt self-promotion, and getting it wrong can get you banned and your brand poisoned.

The approach that works:

Become a genuine contributor first. Starting in May, post program-level analysis content that is actually interesting and valuable on its own merits. Examples: "If you were drafting entire college programs for 2026, here's how I'd rank the Power 4 conferences." "Which 5 programs are most likely to overperform their preseason ranking?" "A case for why mid-major programs are undervalued in college fantasy." Let people engage with the concept organically before you ever mention Rivyls.

When you share the platform, frame it authentically. "I built this thing after running a college football pool on Google Sheets for years. Here it is. Feedback welcome." Reddit responds to authenticity and creators sharing passion projects. It punishes anything that smells like corporate marketing.

Other communities to target: College football Discord servers, CFB Twitter/X (the college football community is massive and vocal), team-specific message boards and forums, Barstool Sports comment sections, The Athletic's CFB community.

Cost: $0. Time investment: 3-5 hours per week starting in May.

Channel 3: Micro-Influencer Partnerships (Best Paid Channel)

You do not need Joe Rogan. You need the college football podcaster with 3,000-15,000 listeners, the SEC YouTuber with 8,000 subscribers, the CFB Twitter account with 20,000 followers who posts memes and hot takes.

Why micro-influencers:

These creators are accessible (they respond to DMs), affordable ($100-500 per partnership), and their audiences are precisely your target market. Their followers trust their recommendations in a way they never trust a Facebook ad. A single genuine endorsement from a trusted CFB voice can drive 50-200 signups.

The deal structure:

Tier 1 (Free): Offer a free premium account and early access. Many creators will mention interesting new products for free just because it gives them content to talk about.

Tier 2 (Performance): Unique referral link that earns them $2-5 for every user who signs up. They only get paid if it works, so your risk is zero.

Tier 3 (Paid): $100-300 flat fee for a dedicated segment, episode mention, or social media post. Reserve this for creators where you've validated their audience matches your target.

Target: Reach out to 30-40 creators. Expect 10-15 to respond positively. Expect 5-8 to actually promote it consistently.

Cost: $1,000-3,000 total for the season. This is your primary paid marketing spend.

Channel 4: University Grassroots (Slow Burn, High Ceiling)

Target student organizations at 15-20 universities: Greek life chapters, sports clubs, student government, intramural sports coordinators, dorm communities.

The pitch: "Run a free Rivyls league for your org this football season. We'll sponsor the prize for the winning team." The "prize" can be as simple as Rivyls-branded swag or a $25-50 Amazon gift card per org.

What you're really buying: 10-20 users per org, all in the 18-22 demographic that will play fantasy sports for the next 20+ years. These are lifetime customers. And student organizations are phenomenal word-of-mouth engines within a campus.

Realistic scope: As a solo founder, start with 3-5 universities where you have personal connections or alumni ties. Don't try to blanket 30 campuses — you can't support that. Quality over quantity.

Cost: $200-500 total (prize sponsorships). Time: 2-3 hours per university for outreach and setup.

4. Commissioner Acquisition Deep Dive

The commissioner is the single most important user in the Rivyls ecosystem. Everything rises and falls with commissioner acquisition and satisfaction. This section details the full commissioner funnel.

The Commissioner Funnel

Stage	Action	How	Target Volume
Awareness	Commissioner hears about Rivyls	Reddit, creator mentions, word of mouth, social media	1,000-3,000 impressions
Interest	Visits landing page or platform	Compelling headline, social proof, clear value prop	300-500 visitors
Signup	Creates an account	Frictionless registration (Google/Apple sign-in)	150-250 signups
League Creation	Creates a league	One-click league creation, clear onboarding	100-150 leagues created
Invitation	Invites friends to league	Shareable link, text/email templates	100-120 invites sent
League Fill	League reaches draft-ready size	Reminder nudges, "X spots left" notifications	75-100 full leagues
Draft	League completes draft	Smooth draft experience, scheduling tools	70-95 completed drafts
Retention	League stays active all season	Weekly scoring, transactions, leaderboard updates	60-80 active leagues

Commissioner Retention Tactics

Before Draft: Onboarding email sequence (welcome, how to set up your league, how to invite friends, draft day tips). Personalized check-in if a commissioner creates a league but doesn't invite anyone within 48 hours.

Draft Day: This is the highest-stakes moment. If the draft experience is buggy, slow, or confusing, commissioners will never come back. Test this relentlessly. Have a support channel (email or Discord) available during peak draft times.

In-Season: Weekly commissioner digest email: league standings, who made transactions, any highlights. Commissioner-specific features: ability to send league announcements, manage disputes, customize scoring (Year 2). End-of-season survey asking what to improve.

Off-Season: "Your league's year in review" email with stats and highlights. Early access to new features. First-to-know when next season opens. The goal is making commissioners feel like insiders, not just users.

5. Weekly Time Allocation by Phase

As a solo founder, your time is your only resource. Here is a realistic breakdown of how your hours should be distributed in each phase, assuming 50-60 hours per week of focused work.

Phase	Development	Marketing & Outreach	Community	User Support	Planning & Admin
Feb-Apr(Build)	70%(35-42 hrs)	5%(2-3 hrs)	10%(5-6 hrs)	5%(2-3 hrs)	10%(5-6 hrs)
May-Jun(Pre-Launch)	55%(27-33 hrs)	15%(7-9 hrs)	15%(7-9 hrs)	5%(2-3 hrs)	10%(5-6 hrs)
July(Beta)	40%(20-24 hrs)	25%(12-15 hrs)	15%(7-9 hrs)	10%(5-6 hrs)	10%(5-6 hrs)
August(Draft Season)	25%(12-15 hrs)	25%(12-15 hrs)	20%(10-12 hrs)	20%(10-12 hrs)	10%(5-6 hrs)
Sep-Jan(In-Season)	30%(15-18 hrs)	15%(7-9 hrs)	15%(7-9 hrs)	25%(12-15 hrs)	15%(7-9 hrs)

CRITICAL: August Is Your Hardest Month

August is when development, marketing, user support, and live operations all peak simultaneously. Plan for this. Clear your calendar. Minimize other commitments. You will be working 60+ hour weeks. This is the month that determines whether the 2026 season succeeds.

6. What NOT to Do (Channels to Avoid)

Knowing what to skip is as important as knowing what to do. These channels are either too expensive, too time-consuming, or too low-ROI for a solo founder at this stage.

Channel	Why to Avoid (For Now)	Waste Risk
Paid Digital Ads(Facebook, Instagram, Google)	Your budget is too small to compete for attention against DraftKings and FanDuel. The targeting is too broad. You would burn through $5,000 in a month with maybe 200 signups at $25 CAC — terrible economics at your stage. Paid ads work when you have a proven funnel and can spend $50K+/month.	**High**
TikTok Content Creation	Unless you are naturally comfortable on camera and can commit to 3-5 videos per week, the time investment is too high relative to the uncertain return. It takes months to build a following, and the algorithm is unpredictable. Being on other people's content is better than creating your own.	**Medium**
Starting Your Own Podcast	Running a podcast takes 5-10 hours per week between recording, editing, and promotion. That time is better spent building the platform. You want to be a guest on other people's podcasts, not running your own.	**Medium**
PR / Press Outreach	Traditional media coverage sounds exciting but rarely converts to signups for a niche product. A TechCrunch article might generate 500 visitors and 20 signups. The same time spent on Reddit and commissioner outreach would yield 10x the results.	**Low-Medium**
Conference / Event Booths	Expensive ($1,000-5,000+), time-consuming (full weekend), and low conversion for a digital product. Save this for Year 2 when you have a polished product and branded materials.	**Low**
Broad Email Blasts / Cold Email	Buying email lists and blasting is spam. It damages your domain reputation, violates CAN-SPAM, and has near-zero conversion. Only email people who opted in.	**High**

7. Realistic Outcome Scenarios

Plan for the conservative scenario, build for the achievable one, and be ready if you get lucky with the optimistic one.

Scenario	Definition	Leagues	Users	What Happened
Conservative	Things went okay, growth was slower than hoped	**30-50**	**300-500**	Commissioner recruitment was harder than expected; 2-3 creator partnerships landed; Reddit posts got moderate engagement; original users expanded to ~40 leagues through personal networks.
Achievable(Target)	Solid execution across all channels	**75-120**	**750-1,200**	Commissioner engine worked well; 5-8 creators actively promoted; 2-3 Reddit posts got traction; university outreach delivered 5-10 org leagues; word-of-mouth kicked in during August.
Optimistic	Something caught fire	**150+**	**1,500+**	A Reddit post went viral, a major CFB personality organically discovered and promoted Rivyls, or a TikTok/Twitter moment generated massive organic interest. Platform must be ready to handle this.

ARCHITECTURE NOTE

The platform architecture must handle 1,500+ concurrent users even if you only expect 500. If you get a viral moment and the site crashes, you will never get those people back. Supabase with PostgreSQL and Vercel's edge deployment can handle this scale comfortably on their Pro tiers.

8. Year 1 Pricing Strategy

Recommendation: Everything is free in Year 1.

This is counterintuitive when you're trying to build a business, but the reasoning is clear:

1. Your goal is users, not revenue. The VC told you to prove 100 leagues and 1,000 users. Revenue means nothing if you can't demonstrate that people want to use the product. Free removes the biggest barrier to trying something new.

2. Charging creates development overhead you can't afford. Payment processing (Stripe integration), refund handling, payout management, tax reporting (1099s for winnings over $600), and state-by-state money transmitter compliance. Each of these is weeks of work. Skip it all in Year 1.

3. Free leagues generate better data. When leagues are free, people complete the full season without worrying about sunk cost. You get cleaner engagement data: do people actually enjoy this, or were they just protecting their entry fee?

4. It sets up Year 2 monetization perfectly. "We had 1,000 users play for free last season with 80% retention through the full season. Now we're introducing paid leagues and premium features." That's a compelling pitch to investors and to users who already love the product.

Year 2 Monetization Preview

When you do introduce monetization in Year 2, the model should be:

Free Tier (always available): Basic leagues, standard scoring, leaderboard. This is your acquisition funnel forever.

Paid Entry Leagues: $20-50 entry fee per user, Rivyls takes a 10-15% rake. Commissioner sets the entry fee. Payouts to top finishers.

Premium Subscription ($4.99/mo or $29.99/yr): Advanced analytics, draft tools, historical data, priority support, premium commissioner tools.

Sponsorships: Once you have 5,000+ users, approach college sports media brands and regional advertisers for sponsored leagues, branded content, and display advertising.

9. Key Metrics & Tracking

These are the numbers you need to track obsessively throughout the 2026 season. They tell you whether the business is working and inform every decision for Year 2.

Category	Metric	Frequency	Why It Matters
Acquisition	**Total signups**	Weekly	Is the top of funnel working?
Acquisition	**Signups by source**	Weekly	Which channels are driving users?
Acquisition	**Commissioner signups**	Weekly	Is the engine working?
Activation	**Leagues created / signups**	Weekly	Are signups converting to leagues?
Activation	**Leagues that reach draft**	Weekly	Are commissioners filling leagues?
Activation	**Avg league fill rate**	Weekly	How many spots per league are filled?
Activation	**Time from signup to league creation**	Monthly	How fast do people act?
Engagement	**Weekly Active Users (WAU)**	Weekly	Are people logging in regularly?
Engagement	**Transactions per user per week**	Weekly	Are people using add/drop features?
Engagement	**Avg session duration**	Weekly	How long do people spend on the platform?
Engagement	**Pages per session**	Monthly	What are people looking at?
Retention	**Week-over-week retention**	Weekly	When do people stop logging in?
Retention	**Full-season completion rate**	End of season	What % played all 18 weeks?
Retention	**Commissioner return intent**	End of season	Survey: "Will you run a league next year?"
Virality	**Invites sent per commissioner**	Monthly	Are commissioners spreading the word?
Virality	**Invite acceptance rate**	Monthly	Are invitees actually joining?
Virality	**Organic signups (no referral)**	Monthly	Is word-of-mouth working?
Satisfaction	**Net Promoter Score (NPS)**	End of season	Would users recommend Rivyls?

Satisfaction	**Support tickets per 100 users**	Weekly	Is the platform stable?

Tools for tracking: Supabase dashboard for database metrics, Vercel Analytics or Plausible (privacy-friendly) for web analytics, a simple Google Sheet for weekly metric snapshots (you already know how to build a great spreadsheet). Don't over-engineer analytics in Year 1. A weekly 15-minute review of these numbers is sufficient.

10. Action Items: Your Next 30 Days

It is February 23, 2026. You have approximately 5 months until the platform needs to be live and approximately 6 months until the season starts. Here is exactly what to do in the next 30 days.

Week 1(Feb 24 - Mar 2)	Development	Action Items
		☐ Finalize database schema in Supabase (users, leagues, rosters, schools, scores, transactions)
		☐ Set up authentication (Supabase Auth with email + Google sign-in)
		☐ Build user registration and login flow
		☐ Set up project repository and deployment pipeline (GitHub + Vercel)

Week 2(Mar 3 - Mar 9)	Development	Action Items
		☐ Build league creation flow (commissioner creates league, sets name and rules)
		☐ Build league invitation system (shareable link generation)
		☐ Start league join flow (user accepts invite, joins league)
		☐ Begin migrating school/program data from Google Sheets to Supabase

Week 3(Mar 10 - Mar 16)	Development + Brand	Action Items
		☐ Continue league management features
		☐ Begin snake draft engine (the most complex feature — start early)
		☐ Secure domain name if not already done
		☐ Start designing landing page wireframe for May launch

Week 4(Mar 17 - Mar 23)	Development + Planning	Action Items
		☐ Continue draft engine development
		☐ Begin ESPN API integration for 2026 season data

		☐ Create a target list of 30-40 micro-influencers/content creators to contact in June
		☐ Identify 3-5 universities for grassroots outreach

THE BOTTOM LINE

You have a validated concept, a working MVP that served real users through a full season, deep technical capability, and a clear market gap. The VC was right that speed matters more than perfection — your moat is built through execution, community, and being first. Ship the platform, fill it with commissioners, and prove the retention metrics that make the business undeniable.

The path is clear: build it by July, fill it by August, prove it by January.

END OF MARKETING PLAN

Rivyls — Draft Programs. Not Players.